

Helix-ecosystem submodule integration

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Master technical specification — Volume 6 (Deployment, Tooling & Operations), nano-detail document `helix-ecosystem-integration.md`. Scope: **how HelixVPN wires every already-incorporated submodules/ member into a concrete role** — `vasic-digital/containers` (sole container orchestration, §11.4.76), `HelixDevelopment/helix_qa` (anti-bluff QA, §11.4.169), `vasic-digital/challenges` (Challenge banks, §11.4.27), `vasic-digital/docs_chain` (doc/DB sync, §11.4.106), `vasic-digital/security` (control-plane defensive libs), `vision_engine` (recording/vision bridge, §11.4.160), `helix_design` (Volume-10 design system, §11.4.162), plus the dev-loop-only members. It deepens [05 §6] (`05-repo-layout-tooling-and-helix-ecosystem.md`) with the **catalogue-first reuse decisions** (§11.4.74 — a per-submodule Catalogue-Check: `reuse|extend|no-match` table) and the **decoupling invariants** (§11.4.28 — submodules stay project-not-aware, reusable). This is a SPEC (describe the wiring; do not build the product). Evidence cited inline: [05 §N], [`svc-telemetry §N`], [`svc-events §N`], [`kubernetes §N`], [`observability §N`], [`disaster-recovery §N`]. The PARKED `remote-testing-infra.md` is out of scope per the blueprint. Unproven facts are marked UNVERIFIED per §11.4.6.

Table of contents

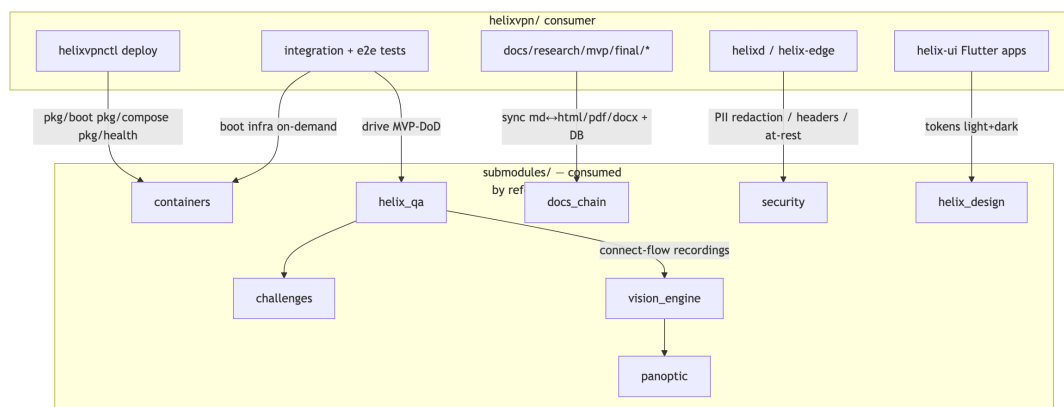
- 0. The three wiring rules that govern every submodule
- 1. Catalogue-Check table (§11.4.74 reuse decisions)
- 2. containers — sole orchestration + on-demand test infra

- [3. helix_qa — anti-bluff QA orchestrator](#)
 - [4. challenges — the Challenge engine](#)
 - [5. docs_chain — spec + workable-items sync](#)
 - [6. security — control-plane defensive libraries](#)
 - [7. vision_engine + panoptic — recording/vision bridge](#)
 - [8. helix_design — the Volume-10 design system](#)
 - [9. doc_processor + the dev-loop-only members](#)
 - [10. Decoupling invariants \(§11.4.28\) & enforcement](#)
 - [11. UNVERIFIED register](#)
 - [Sources verified](#)
-

0. The three wiring rules that govern every submodule

Every submodule wiring in this document obeys three constitution rules, stated once:

1. **Consumed by reference, never copied (§11.4.106/.80, [05 §6]).** A submodule is invoked at its path / imported as a package — never vendored-by-copy. A copy diverges silently.
2. **Catalogue-first (§11.4.74).** Before any new helper is scaffolded in-project, the submodule catalogue is surveyed; $\geq 80\%$ match $\Rightarrow$ reuse; 80% + with gaps $\Rightarrow$ **extend upstream** (PR), never duplicate the 80% ; no match $\Rightarrow$ build, with the survey recorded as a Catalogue-Check: line (§1).
3. **Decoupling (§11.4.28(B)).** A submodule is given **zero** HelixVPN-specific context — no hardcoded hostnames, asset names, tenant assumptions. Project specifics enter only via config injection (env var / config struct / constructor param). Enforced by CM-OWNED-SUBMODULE-DECOUPLING (§10).



1. Catalogue-Check table (§11.4.74 reuse decisions)

Per §11.4.74 every submodule role records a reuse decision (reuse | extend | no-match) so a future contributor does not re-implement an existing capability. This is the consolidated ledger (derived from [05 §6.1]):

Submodule	Catalogue-Check	What HelixVPN reuses / extends	Phase
containers	reuse vasic-digital/ containers@<sha>	pkg/boot/pkg/ compose/pkg/ health for deploy render + on- demand test infra; extend only if a runtime primitive is missing (then PR upstream, §2)	0–1
helix_qa	reuse HelixDevelopment/ helix_qa@<sha>	anti-bluff QA orchestrator drives the 8 MVP-DoD criteria; HelixVPN supplies <i>test banks</i> , not engine code (§3)	1
challenges	reuse vasic-digital/ challenges@<sha>	Challenge engine; HelixVPN authors Challenge <i>definitions</i> referencing ATM- ids (§4)	1
docs_chain	reuse vasic-digital/ docs_chain@<sha>	doc-export + DB- sync engine; HelixVPN supplies .docs_chain/ contexts/*.yaml data, not engine code (§5)	0+
security	reuse → extend-as- needed vasic- digital/ security@<sha>	PII-redaction, HTTP security headers, AES-256- GCM at-rest, SSRF- deny, privesc scan (§6); extend	1

Submodule	Catalogue-Check	What HelixVPN reuses / extends	Phase
vision_engine	reuse vision_engine@<sha>	upstream for any missing primitive video/screenshot evidence analysis for UI Challenges (§7) — test-infra, never shipped in an app bundle	1–2
panoptic	reuse panoptic@<sha>	UI automation + capture harness feeding vision_engine (§7)	1–2
doc_processor	reuse doc_processor@<sha>	feature-map extraction → per-feature Status ledger cross-check (§9)	1
helix_design	extend vasic-digital/ helix_design@<sha>	the OpenDesign-based design system (Volume 10); HelixVPN is a primary consumer + extends it with brand tokens (§8)	1+
llm_provider	no-match (conditional)	binds ONLY if Phase-2 ships LLM-assisted policy authoring (D-LLM-POLICY); else dev-only (§9)	2 (opt)
llm_orchestrator	reuse (dev-loop only)	subagent orchestration for the <i>build</i> loop; NOT a runtime dependency (§9)	dev-only
llms_verifier	reuse (dev-loop only)	verifies the dev loop's LLM ("do you see my code?"); NOT a runtime component (§9)	dev-only

The @<sha> placeholders are the pinned submodule pointers (§11.4.26 step 7); the actual SHAs live in .gitmodules + helix-deps.yaml [05 §3.2], bumped in the same commit as cascade work.

2. containers — sole orchestration + on-demand test infra

containers is the **only** sanctioned path to docker/podman/k8s from HelixVPN (§11.4.76 — no ad-hoc docker/podman outside pkg/boot/pkg/compose/pkg/health, [05 §6.3]). Two concrete uses, both load-bearing:

(A) On-demand integration-test infra — the §11.4.76 on-demand-infra invariant: operators never podman machine by hand; the test entry point boots the infra [05 §6.3(A)]. This is the seam every sibling deploy doc's anti-bluff plan depends on ([kubernetes §10], [ha-and-multiregion §8], [observability §8], [disaster-recovery §7] all boot PG/Redis/cluster via containers):

```
// helix-go/internal/store/integration_test.go (from [05 §6.3A],
// the canonical pattern)
import (
    "digital.vasic.containers/pkg/boot"
    "digital.vasic.containers/pkg/health"
)
func TestWatchNetworkMapDeltaStream(t *testing.T) {
    ctx := context.Background()
    infra := boot.Compose(ctx, boot.Spec{                                //
        rootless Podman (§11.4.161)
        Services: []boot.Service{
            {Name: "pg", Image: "docker.io/library/postgres:16", Port: 5432},
            {Name: "redis", Image: "docker.io/library/redis:7", Port: 6379},
        },
    })
    t.Cleanup(func() { infra.Down(ctx) })                                //
        §11.4.14 quiescent teardown
    health.WaitReady(ctx, infra,
        30*time.Second)           // real readiness probe, not a
        sleep
    // ... drive enroll → advertise → policy → assert MapDelta
        [svc-events §7.1]
}
```

Anti-bluff (§11.4.76(5)): an integration test claiming to exercise streamed WatchNetworkMap MUST actually boot PG+Redis via the submodule — a short-circuit fake that skips boot is a §11.4 violation [05 §6.3]. The paired mutation: remove boot.Compose → the test FAILs (proves it wasn't a fake) [05 §11].

(B) Deploy generation — `helixvpnctl deploy {quadlet,compose,kube}` renders all three substrates through `containers/pkg/compose` so one in-code spec yields three substrates (§11.4.81 parity), not three hand-maintained files [05 §6.3(B), `kubernetes §1/§10`].

Extend, don't fork (§11.4.74). If a runtime primitive HelixVPN needs is missing from `containers` (e.g. a `kind/k3d` boot for the [kubernetes §10] cluster integration test), it is **added upstream via PR**, never worked around with a raw `podman/kind` command in-project. The `Catalogue-Check: extend vasic-digital/containers@<sha>` line records it [05 §6.3].

3. `helix_qa` — anti-bluff QA orchestrator

`helix_qa` is the autonomous QA orchestrator that drives the **8 MVP-DoD acceptance criteria** with captured evidence, crash detection, and ticket generation (§11.4.27/.107/.158, [05 §6.1]). HelixVPN supplies *test banks*, not engine code (consumed by reference).

```
# from [05 §8] — the QA entry point
qa: ; go run ./submodules/helix_qa/cmd/orchestrator --suite mvp-dod
    # 8 acceptance Challenges
```

Wiring contract:

- **HelixVPN registers test banks** (per-app, per-service, per-platform) that `helix_qa` drives in autonomous sessions, each PASS citing captured wire evidence per check (§11.4.27/.169). Banks reference the workable-item ATM-ids (§4) so a feature, its Challenge, and its DB row are one chain [05 §10].
- **`helix_qa` consumes the §11.4.116 sync channel** an autonomous test framework must expose (JSONL event stream + atomic status snapshot the conductor tails) — the orchestrator's per-verdict events carry the evidence path [`svc-coordinator §9`] pattern applied at the suite level.
- **Decoupling:** `helix_qa` is project-agnostic; HelixVPN registers its endpoints, package ids, sink hosts at runtime via the public API (§11.4.116), never hardcoded into the submodule (§10).

The 8 MVP-DoD criteria (from [04_P1], surfaced via [05 §6.1]) become executable Challenges (§4); `helix_qa` is the *driver*, `challenges` is the *engine* (§4). A green `helix_qa` suite with no captured per-check evidence is a §11.4 bluff — the orchestrator's charter is precisely to make "tests pass but feature broken" mechanically impossible (§11.4.169).

4. challenges — the Challenge engine

challenges (`digital.vasic.challenges`) is the Challenge engine underpinning the anti-bluff acceptance Challenges — the MVP DoD expressed as executable Challenges scoring PASS only on positive captured evidence (§11.4.27/.5/.69, [05 §6.1]).

Wiring contract:

- **HelixVPN authors Challenge definitions** (not engine code) referencing each PWU's ATM-id + dispatching to its on-device/integration test + scoring PASS only on positive captured evidence per §11.4.5 [05 §6.1, §10]. Example Challenge classes for HelixVPN:

Challenge	Asserts (captured evidence)
CH-CONVERGENCE-1S	event→delta p99 < 1 s under a policy flip [observability §3]; histogram dump
CH-REVOKE-1S	device revoke → peer-removal delta < 1 s [svc-coordinator §4.5]; revoke-to-close timer
CH-NO-LOGGING	schemalint green vs the deployed DB (runtime signature §11.4.108) [svc-telemetry §7]
CH-NEED-TO-KNOW	a denied peer never appears in any node's snapshot (C4) [svc-coordinator §9]; per-node peer-set
CH-DEPLOY-PARITY	quadlet/compose/k8s boot the same gateway; gateway status GREEN on each [05 §11]

- **challenges is the engine, helix_qa the driver (§3)**. `helix_qa` runs the challenge banks; the challenges submodule scores them. Neither is copied; both are referenced.
- **Decoupling**: Challenge definitions live in-project (`tools/helixqa/banks/` per [05 §11.4.58] pattern); the engine stays project-agnostic.

A Challenge that scores PASS on a non-functional feature is the same defect class as a bluffing unit test (the anti-bluff covenant's founding case) — the engine + the captured-evidence requirement together forbid it.

5. docs_chain — spec + workable-items sync

This very specification set is a `docs_chain` corpus (§11.4.106, [05 §6.4]). `docs_chain` is the canonical mechanical doc/DB sync engine — HelixVPN supplies *context data*, not engine code.

```
# .docs_chain/contexts/helixvpn_spec.yaml (from [05 §6.4])
version: 1
```

```

nodes:
- id: spec-v06-deploy
  glob: docs/research/mvp/final/v06-deploy/
      *.md          # these five docs + siblings
  transforms:
    - exec: "pandoc {src} -o {src%.md}.html"
    - exec: "weasyprint {src%.md}.html {src%.md}.pdf"
    - exec: "pandoc {src} -o {src%.md}.docx"          #
      §11.4.153 DOCX for the Status ledger class
- id: workable-items
  sync:
    - left: docs/.workable_items.db                  # git-
      tracked SSoT (§11.4.95)
      right: docs/Issues.md
      authority: db                                  # DB
      wins; the doc is a view

```

Wiring contract:

- **Engine by reference, contexts by data (§11.4.28).** HelixVPN registers `.docs_chain/contexts/*.yaml` declaring each `final/*.md` → `.html/.pdf/.docx` + the `workable-items` DB [?] generated views. `state.json` + `*.docs_chain.tmp` are gitignored [05 §6.4].
- **Content-hash change detection (§11.4.86, NOT mtime)** — a doc re-exports only when its content hash changes.
- **Invoked by make docs-sync, gated by make docs-verify** (the deterministic CI/pre-build gate, §11.4.106(C)) [05 §8]. A backdated `.html` → `docs-verify` FAILs [05 §11].
- **Anti-bluff (§11.4.106(E)):** the engine NEVER fakes a transform — a missing `pandoc/weasyprint` surfaces a typed `ToolAbsentError` + honest `SKIP-with-reason`, never a fake `PASS` / partial write. Combined with §11.4.168 exported-document visual validation, a committed PDF that leaks raw Mermaid source as body text is caught.

These five `v06-deploy` docs are themselves `docs_chain` nodes — their `.html/.pdf/.docx` siblings are generated, not hand-maintained, in the refinement pass (§11.4.65/.153).

6. security — control-plane defensive libraries

`security` (`digital.vasic.security`) provides the control-plane defensive libraries that keep the no-logging + zero-trust promises honest at the code layer ([05 §6.1], doc 04). Reuse → extend per §11.4.74.

Capability	HelixVPN wiring	Composes with
PII redaction in logs	wrap helixd's slog so any accidental device-id/ip in a log line is redacted — keeps no-logging honest even on the error path	C3, [svc-telemetry §7]
HTTP security headers	middleware on the Gin REST surface ([svc-events §3.6] Console API) — HSTS, CSP, no-sniff	doc 04
AES-256-GCM at-rest	encrypt the data-dir secrets (helixvpncctl init writes creds at mode 0600, [05 §5.3])	§11.4.10
SSRF-deny on outbound	guard any control-plane outbound call (OIDC discovery, webhook) against SSRF	doc 04
privesc scan of the edge container	CI/pre-build scan asserting the edge holds no caps beyond the canonical {NET_ADMIN, NET_RAW} (plus the /dev/net/tun device), no shell, read-only rootfs [podman-quadlets §3.2, kubernetes §6, research-podman_k8s §2]	§11.4.133

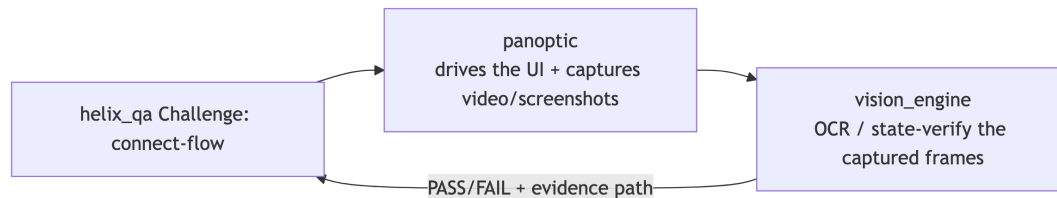
Reconciled (§11.4.35, 2026-06-26): the privesc scan asserts **no caps beyond the canonical edge set {NET_ADMIN, NET_RAW}** — matching the quadlet/Compose/K8s substrates, not the earlier "ONLY NET_ADMIN" wording. NET_RAW is **CONFIRMED required** by [research-podman_k8s §2] for the kernel-mode WireGuard fast path; /dev/net/tun is the userspace-fallback device. A scan that flagged NET_RAW as excess would have made the Q4/DC4 capability gates and this security gate non-satisfiable together — they now agree on one set (§11.4.6).

Wiring contract:

- **Reuse the libraries; extend upstream for gaps (§11.4.74).** A missing primitive (e.g. a no-logging-aware log redactor tuned to the C3 forbidden-key set [svc-telemetry §7.1]) is added *upstream* via PR, never duplicated in-project.
- **Decoupling:** the security libs take the forbidden-key set / header policy as *config*, never hardcoded to HelixVPN (§10) — so the same redactor serves any no-logging project.
- **UNVERIFIED — exact security public surface.** The library's precise API is not enumerated in this writing context; the *roles* above are asserted from [05 §6.1], the API binding is flagged for the integration pass (§11).

7. vision_engine + panoptic — recording/vision bridge

vision_engine + panoptic are **test-infra, never product** [05 §6.2] — they validate the Flutter apps' user-visible flows with captured video/screenshot evidence and never ship inside an app bundle.



Wiring contract:

- **panoptic** = the capture harness: drives the Client/Console/Connector apps (web+desktop+mobile) and captures **window-scoped** (§11.4.154) video/screenshots of the real connect flow.
 - **vision_engine** = the analysis: OCR/state-verify the captured frames against SPECIFY-phase expected patterns, producing a per-frame PASS/FAIL with an evidence path — the §11.4.160 vision-verified recording bridge feeding helix_qa.
 - **Composes the recording mandates:** §11.4.107(10) self-validated analyzer (golden-good/golden-bad), §11.4.117 CV/OCR pixel oracle for non-introspectable UIs, §11.4.159 window-specific recording + vision validation, §11.4.163 media-validation pipeline. A connect-flow Challenge that records a *frozen* frame or a *bluff* "Connected" label is caught by the liveness + content oracle.
 - **Decoupling:** both take the app under test + expected patterns as runtime config; they are project-agnostic capture/analysis engines (§10).
-

8. helix_design — the Volume-10 design system

helix_design (vasic-digital/helix_design) is the **OpenDesign-based design system** that is its own decoupled reusable submodule and the whole subject of **Volume 10** (MASTER_INDEX.md, §11.4.162). From the deployment/integration view this document owns only the *wiring*, not the design content (Volume 10 owns that):

- **Catalogue-Check: extend (§11.4.74).** HelixVPN is a primary consumer *and* extends helix_design with its brand tokens (light+dark) — extending OpenDesign upstream for any missing pattern, never ad-hoc CSS (§11.4.162).

- **Consumed by the three Flutter apps** (app_access/app_connector/app_console, [05 §2]) via the helix_design package → design tokens drive palette/type/spacing/component tokens; every component ships light+dark variants (§11.4.162).
- **Decoupling (§11.4.28):** helix_design carries no HelixVPN-specific assets hardcoded — brand colors/tokens are injected; the submodule is reusable by any future app [MASTER_INDEX V10].
- **Visual-regression coverage (§11.4.162/.168):** every UI change carries before/after screenshot diff coverage, captured via panoptic/vision_engine (§7).

The full design-system depth (every screen, component, token-export pipeline, per-platform adaptation) is **Volume 10**, not this document — this section only records the *integration seam* so the ecosystem map is complete (§11.4.6 — no submodule silently unaddressed).

9. doc_processor + the dev-loop-only members

doc_processor — feature-map extraction from this spec set → the per-feature Status ledger (§11.4.153) coverage cross-check [05 §6.1]. Wiring: doc_processor parses the final/*.md corpus, extracts the feature map, and cross-checks it against the codebase feature ledger so a code-present feature missing from the Status doc (or vice-versa) is caught (§11.4.118). Reuse, by reference.

Dev-loop-only members (§11.4.6 — N/A justified, never silently dropped, [05 §6.2]):

Member	Classification	Why runtime-N/A
llm_orchestrator	dev-loop only	headless subagent orchestration for the <i>build/QA</i> loop (§11.4.70); HelixVPN ships no LLM in its data/control path — not linked into helixd/helix-edge
llms_verifier	dev-loop only	verifies the dev loop's LLM ("do you see my code?" gate, §11.4.78); not a HelixVPN runtime component
llm_provider	conditional (D-LLM-POLICY)	binds ONLY if Phase-2 ships LLM-assisted policy authoring (a Console convenience: "natural language → ACL"); if cut, stays dev-only. NOT in the packet/control path [05 §6.2, §12]

Marking these runtime-N/A is the honest classification (§11.4.6), not an omission: HelixVPN *uses* them to **build itself** (autonomous subagent loop), but they are not product runtime dependencies. D-LLM-POLICY is the surfaced decision [05 §12] — default "no" until product-validated.

10. Decoupling invariants (§11.4.28) & enforcement

The decoupling invariant is the rule every section above repeats: **no submodule may carry HelixVPN-specific context**. Concretely:

Invariant (§11.4.28)	What it forbids	How HelixVPN complies
(B) project-not-aware	hardcoded helixvpn hostnames/asset names/tenant assumptions INSIDE a submodule	all project specifics injected via env var / config struct / constructor param (containers boot.Spec, helix_qa runtime register, docs_chain context YAML, security config)
(C) flat dependency layout	nested own-org .gitmodules chains	submodules are flat under helixvpn/submodules/ [05 §2/ §3]; deps reached from the root, no nesting
equal-codebase engineering (A)	treating a submodule as second-class	each owned submodule gets the same anti-bluff/test/doc attention; extensions go upstream via PR (§11.4.74)

Enforcement (the gates from [05] + §11.4.28):

- **CM-OWNED-SUBMODULE-DECOUPLING** — pre-commit greps the submodule diff for parent-project context (a helixvpn literal inside a submodule = FAIL).
- **CM-OWNED-SUBMODULE-LAYOUT** — pre-merge verifies flat location + no nested own-org submodules + root-level dependency lookup [05 §11].
- **CM-OWNED-SUBMODULE-EQUAL-ENGINEERING** — release-gate sweep audits parity.
- **Pointer hygiene (§11.4.26 step 7):** submodule pointers bumped to upstream HEAD in the same commit as cascade work; helix-deps.yaml declares own-org deps [05 §3.2].

The catalogue-first + decoupling pair is the whole governance story: §11.4.74 stops HelixVPN *reimplementing* what a submodule already does; §11.4.28 stops HelixVPN *contaminating* the submodule it reuses. Together they keep every submodules/ member a clean, reusable, independently-testable component — and keep HelixVPN a thin consumer that wires them, not a fork that absorbs them.

11. UNVERIFIED register

#	UNVERIFIED item	Why / status
U1	Exact public API surface of security (§6)	roles asserted from [05 §6.1]; precise API binding flagged for the integration pass
U2	Exact helix_qa / challenges registration API (§3/§4)	charter asserted; the concrete bank-registration call signature is submodule-version-specific
U3	vision_engine/panoptic driver API for Flutter (§7)	the capture/analysis roles are asserted; the exact app-driving binding is flagged
U4	doc_processor feature-extraction output schema (§9)	role asserted from [05 §6.1]; the ledger cross-check format is flagged
U5	D-LLM-POLICY resolution (§9)	deferred to Phase 2, default "no" [05 §12] — not resolved here
U6	Submodule pinned SHAs (§1)	placeholders; live in .gitmodules/helix-deps.yaml, bumped per §11.4.26 step 7

Sources verified

- 05-repo-layout-tooling-and-helix-ecosystem.md §2 (submodules/tree), §3.2 (helix-deps.yaml, flat layout), §6 (the ecosystem role map — the spine of this document), §6.1 (per-submodule role table), §6.2 (dev-only / conditional justifications), §6.3 (containers: on-demand infra + deploy gen), §6.4 (docs_chain context + workable-items DB), §8 (make qa/docs-sync/docs-verify), §11 (anti-bluff evidence plan), §12 (D-LLM-POLICY decision) — [05].
- MASTER_INDEX.md Volume 10 (helix_design as the decoupled OpenDesign submodule, §11.4.162) — [MASTER_INDEX].

- `v03-control-plane/svc-telemetry.md` §7 (no-logging schema-lint the security redactor + the CH-NO-LOGGING Challenge compose with) — `[svc-telemetry]`.
- `v03-control-plane/svc-events.md` §3.6 (Console API surface the security headers protect), §7.1 (the WatchNetworkMap path the containers-booted integration test drives) — `[svc-events]`.
- `v03-control-plane/svc-coordinator.md` §4.5 (revoke <1s → CH-REVOKE-1S), §9 (per-feature Challenge/test-type mapping the helix_qa banks instantiate) — `[svc-coordinator]`.
- `v06-deploy/kubernetes.md` §6/§10 (edge privesc scan target; containers-booted cluster integration test) · `v06-deploy/observability.md` §3/§8 (the SLO Challenges) · `v06-deploy/disaster-recovery.md` §7 (containers-booted restore-verification) — sibling docs.

Constitution bindings applied: §11.4.44 (revision header), §11.4.74 (catalogue-first reuse — the §1 Catalogue-Check table), §11.4.28 (decoupling invariants + enforcement gates §10), §11.4.76/.161 (containers sole orchestration + rootless, §2), §11.4.106/.80 (consumed-by-reference, never copied, §5), §11.4.27/.169 (anti-bluff QA via helix_qa/challenges, §3/§4), §11.4.107/.117/.159/.160/.163 (vision/recording bridge, §7), §11.4.162 (helix_design/OpenDesign, §8), §11.4.6 (no submodule silently dropped — dev-only/conditional justified, UNVERIFIED register §11), §11.4.26 step 7 (pointer hygiene).